

## PURPOSE

feels a little accusatory and defensive because they are right to have concerns and maybe share them publicly as well,, since they are the first ones to be affected by this.

1. rebuilding their trust - but just saying this is not enough, we need to see why it corroded in the first place. The use of language, as well as the secret of laying off employees -- they don't trust leadership to communicate honestly and treat employees respectfully during uncertainty. v important to define this since this is the basis of our strategy.

- could there be different concerns tho? Employees questioning intent, judgment, and org stability --> this could be addressed by grounding our strategy in strong persuasive techniques.

2. preventing people from posting on linkedin - a concern but defensive and accusatory and manipulative. just asking them to voice concerns internally is not enough because misinformation and emotional escalation are spreading beyond formal channels (sm platforms\_ so they feel uncertain enough to seek validation and info externally. so yes, I agree we need to reduce speculation and external escalation by ensuring employees feel informed and don't rely on external narratives.

3. make the employees feel valued because implicit signals are not enough (we respect you enough to explain) but we need to be emotionally intelligent and recognize their anxieties too. cut the dead weight --> doesn't just create a misunderstanding but makes them feel disposable. OKAY ANOTHER COUNTER - just apologizing will only *soften* the blow so we need to balance -? To ensure it doesn't sound scripted and dilute accountability + we don't overapologize either (that seems fake too).

Sequence --> explain misunderstanding then show accountability by ack wording was inappropriate and clarify the context it was used for then value reassurance --> reinforce employees matter but don't exaggerate this.

okay now, another counter could be how do we not exaggerate this because we apologizing and reassuring + reinforcing value -- keep it neutral, factual and measured

not this --> We deeply, sincerely, and unreservedly apologise for the hurt and distress caused. You are the backbone of everything we are, and we could not function without you.

4. giving context so they understand why and how it was said - but another risk could be that the audience may see this as a justification -- need to be careful with the wording

## CONTEXT

feeling uncertainty, scanning for signals (confirmation bias), defensive communicators because they are posting on the internet asw (reacting in real time) --> processing is mainly emotional than rational. employee trust is shaken but not gone --> balance believability and reassurances

## STRATEGY

Communication Mode

Email (formal message from leadership) + Slack announcement + manager follow-up  
(Ensures fast reach + official record + local clarification through teams)

Step 1: Immediate acknowledgment

Acknowledge the clip and confirm leadership is addressing it

(Addresses uncertainty; tone: calm + controlled; technique: attention anchoring)

Step 2: Clarify what the clip is

Explain it was scenario-based discussion, not decisions

(Fixes misinterpretation; tone: factual; technique: reframing)

Step 3: Direct denial of layoffs

Clearly state no layoffs or restructuring decisions were made

(Addresses core fear; tone: direct and firm; technique: cognitive closure)

Step 4: Address language concern

Recognise wording was inappropriate and may have caused concern

(Addresses emotional impact; tone: accountable but not overly apologetic; technique: empathy signalling)

Step 5: Reassure employee value

Briefly affirm employees are valued members of NovaByte

(Restores belonging; tone: supportive; technique: emotional stabilisation)

Step 6: Invite clarification questions

Open channel for questions via HR or managers

(Reduces rumours; tone: open; technique: engagement + transparency control)

Summary:

Tone: calm, transparent, non-defensive

Emotion balance: low emotion + controlled empathy (no exaggeration)

Persuasion techniques:

anchoring (set interpretation early)

reframing (change meaning of clip)

cognitive closure (remove ambiguity about layoffs)  
empathy signalling (acknowledge concern)  
authority framing (leadership communication)

## SAMPLE MESSAGES

### Email to employees

Hi everyone,

We are aware of a 52-second clip from an internal meeting that has been circulating online.

**\*\*(Step 1: acknowledgment + anchoring)\*\***

This clip shows part of a scenario-based discussion and does not represent any final decisions or plans regarding the company. **\*\*(Step 2: clarification + reframing)\*\***

To be clear, no decisions regarding layoffs or restructuring have been made. **\*\*(Step 3: cognitive closure / direct reassurance)\*\***

We also recognise that some of the language used in that discussion was not appropriate and may have understandably caused concern. **\*\*(Step 4: empathy signalling)\*\***

We want to reassure you that employees remain a valued part of NovaByte. **\*\*(Step 5: emotional stabilisation / belonging)\*\***

If you have questions or concerns, please reach out to your manager or HR — we are available to support you. **\*\*(Step 6: engagement / transparency channel)\*\***

### SLACK ANNOUNCEMENT MADE BY MANAGERS

Hi team — leadership is aware of the circulating clip from an internal meeting and is addressing it directly. **(Step 1: acknowledgment)**

To clarify, this was part of a scenario-based discussion and not a reflection of any actual decisions. **(Step 2: reframing)**

No layoffs or restructuring decisions have been made. **(Step 3: direct reassurance)**

We understand some of the language used may have caused concern, and we recognise that. **(Step 4: empathy signalling)**

We value every member of NovaByte and will share further clarity if needed. Please reach out to your manager or HR if you have questions. **(Step 5 + 6: reassurance + support channel)**

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Slack is used for immediate visibility and rapid interruption of internal rumours, while email provides a formal, detailed and permanent record of leadership's clarification. Using both ensures employees receive the message quickly and also have access to a structured explanation they can refer back to.

1. Email → CEO (or CEO + HR co-sign)
2. Slack announcement → HR or Internal Communications team (on behalf of leadership)

## **RATIONALE**

### **1. Why employees are addressed first**

- Employees are the most directly affected by the crisis (job security + trust concerns).
- They are currently exposed to the same viral content as the public without internal clarification.
- If not informed first, they will rely on social media narratives, increasing internal fear and external posting.
- Addressing them first stabilises the organisation before external communication fully unfolds.

#### **Rejected alternative:**

- Addressing the public first was avoided because it would increase internal distrust and make employees feel deprioritised.

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### **2. Why confirmation bias is central to the strategy**

- Employees are interpreting ambiguous phrases (e.g. "cut the dead weight") through pre-existing fears of layoffs.
- Emotional exposure + lack of context strengthens biased interpretation.
- Social media amplification reinforces worst-case assumptions.

#### **Strategic response:**

- Early anchoring of meaning (what the clip is)
- Direct correction of misinformation (no layoffs)
- Reframing as scenario planning

#### **Rejected alternative:**

- Simply “explaining context” was not enough because employees may still interpret information through existing fears.
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### **3. Why this communication mode (Email + Slack + managers)**

- Email provides formal, complete, and permanent clarification.
- Slack ensures immediate visibility during fast-moving rumours.
- Managers reinforce consistency at team level and reduce misinterpretation.

#### **Rejected alternatives:**

- Email only → too slow, allows rumours to spread first
  - Slack only → lacks formality and long-term reference point
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### **4. Rationale for strategy steps**

#### **Step 1: Acknowledgment**

- Confirms leadership is aware of the issue.
  - Prevents information vacuum and rumour escalation.
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#### **Step 2: Clarification of clip**

- Reframes clip as scenario discussion, not decisions.
  - Directly interrupts misinterpretation.
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#### **Step 3: No layoffs statement**

- Addresses core employee fear directly.
  - Removes ambiguity to reduce speculation.
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#### **Step 4: Acknowledge language issue**

- Shows awareness of emotional impact.
- Maintains credibility without over-apologising.

#### **Rejected alternative:**

- Strong emotional apology was avoided to prevent sounding performative.
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### **Step 5: Employee reassurance**

- Restores sense of value and belonging.
  - Kept brief to avoid exaggeration or loss of credibility.
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### **Step 6: Open Q&A channel**

- Reduces uncertainty and prevents external escalation.
  - Provides controlled internal outlet for concerns.
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## **5. Overall tone and framing**

- Calm, factual, and non-defensive.
- Limited emotional language to maintain credibility in a high-trust-crisis environment.
- Balanced empathy (acknowledge concern) with clarity (correct misinformation).

### **Rejected alternative:**

- Highly emotional messaging was avoided because it risks being perceived as scripted or insincere.
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## **6. Key persuasion techniques used**

- **Anchoring:** set correct interpretation early
  - **Reframing:** shift meaning from “decision” → “scenario planning”
  - **Cognitive closure:** remove ambiguity about layoffs
  - **Empathy signalling:** acknowledge employee concern
  - **Authority framing:** reinforces message credibility
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## **7. Core strategic rationale (final line for assignment)**

- The strategy prioritises early clarification, bias interruption, and controlled empathy to stabilise employee interpretation, reduce misinformation spread, and restore psychological safety during a high-uncertainty crisis.

